

your children. I once figured out that I spent an average of four dollars more on impulse buys when my children were with me, and when I was working so hard to save thirty dollars in each trip, that four dollars could have made it an extra sixteen-dollar savings each month.

If you have to take your children, involve them in your shopping. Even toddlers can play a match game, finding the product on the shelf that is pictured on the coupon. Make your shopping trips a real-life math lesson. Have your child tell you which package of gum is the better deal—the one priced at eighty-nine cents or the packages that are on sale three for two dollars. Allow one treat at the end of the shopping trip if they've behaved. I liked to reward my children with a twenty-five-cent lollipop if they didn't make me out to be the sucker on a shopping trip.

Use a grocery list. Research supports this. Having a list minimizes impulse buys. That said, I am going to go out on a limb and suggest that as a couponer, there are times when you shouldn't shop from your list. Once you get the hang of this hobby, you will be carrying your coupons with you everywhere you go: on vacations, on those quick "pick up the milk" trips, and even when you go out on a date with your husband. Why? Because sometimes the best deal in a store is an unadvertised one. It might be discounted diapers stacked up in a cart at the front of the store, or a clearance shelf located at the back. Seasoned couponers learn to take their coupons with them everywhere so that when they run across a cart full of diapers priced at four dollars a pack or deodorant marked down to one dollar, they can combine that dramatic savings with their coupons and get the products for *free*. That is when you should forget the list and snatch up